

Contributing with GitHub

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This guide is for contributors who are comfortable using GitHub, or who are willing to use it for a specific correction or review comment. GitHub is useful because it keeps each suggestion visible, reviewable, and linked to the part of the manual that may change.

Use the non-GitHub guide instead if you prefer to send comments by email, shared document, annotated PDF, or meeting notes.

Choose the Right Route

Use a **GitHub issue** when you want to report a problem, suggest a change, add specialist context, or ask maintainers to make the edit.

Use a **pull request** when you want to make the edit directly in the repository and ask maintainers to review it.

Use a **discussion with the maintainer** before opening a large pull request if the contribution would change the structure of a chapter, add a substantial new case study, or introduce sensitive policy, legal, or methodological claims.

Option 1: Open an Issue

Issues are the easiest GitHub route for most contributors.

1. Open the public manual website:

<https://un-cebd-mobile-data.github.io/mobile-phone-data-handbook/>

2. Find the chapter, section, paragraph, table, figure, or reference that needs attention.
3. Copy the page URL from your browser address bar.
4. Open the repository issues page:

<https://github.com/un-cebd-mobile-data/mobile-phone-data-handbook/issues>

5. Select **New issue**.

6. Add a short, specific title.

Good titles identify the location and the change, for example:

Clarify data access responsibilities in Chapter 3

7. Add the suggestion using this template:

```
## Page or chapter
```

```
Paste the page URL, chapter title, section heading, or file name here.
```

```
## Current text or issue
```

```
Paste the current sentence, paragraph, table entry, figure caption, reference, or describe the issue
```

Suggested change

Write the proposed replacement text, or describe what should change.

Reason

Explain why the change is needed. Include practical context, evidence, or references where useful.

Type of contribution

- [] Typo or wording
- [] Factual correction
- [] Methodological clarification
- [] Policy, legal, or governance clarification
- [] Citation or reference
- [] Example, case study, or practical resource
- [] Structure, navigation, or accessibility
- [] Other

Permission or sensitivity check

Confirm that the suggestion does not include confidential, proprietary, restricted, or personally id

8. Select **Submit new issue**.
9. Create a separate issue for unrelated suggestions.

Option 2: Edit a Page in GitHub

Use this route for small text corrections when you are comfortable editing Markdown or Quarto files in the browser.

1. Open the manual website page you want to change.
2. Use the page's GitHub edit link if it is available, or locate the corresponding `.qmd` file in the repository.
3. Select the pencil icon to edit the file.
4. Make the smallest clear change that solves the issue.
5. Add a short description of the change.
6. Follow GitHub's prompts to propose the change as a pull request.

Small pull requests are easier to review when they focus on one topic, chapter, or correction.

Option 3: Work Locally and Open a Pull Request

Use this route for larger edits, repeated changes across files, or updates that need a local preview.

1. Clone the repository.

```
git clone https://github.com/un-cebd-mobile-data/mobile-phone-data-handbook.git
cd mobile-phone-data-handbook
```

2. Create a branch for the contribution.

```
git switch -c update-short-description
```

3. Edit the relevant `.qmd`, `.md`, `.bib`, image, or support file.
4. Preview the manual locally.

```
quarto preview
```

5. For broader changes, render the full manual.

```
bash scripts/render_book.sh
```

6. Commit the change with a clear message.

```
git add path/to/changed-file.qmd  
git commit -m "Clarify data access responsibilities"
```

7. Push the branch and open a pull request.

```
git push -u origin update-short-description
```

Pull Request Checklist

Before opening a pull request, check that:

- the change has a clear purpose and scope;
- unrelated formatting, whitespace, or generated output has not been changed accidentally;
- links and references have been checked where possible;
- any new example, case study, figure, table, or quotation has publication permission;
- no confidential, proprietary, restricted, or personally identifiable information has been included;
- the manual still renders, or you have explained why you could not render it.

Review Expectations

Maintainers may edit accepted contributions for consistency with the manual's terminology, structure, and tone. They may also ask for supporting evidence, permission details, or a narrower scope before merging a change.

Substantive subject-matter contributions may require review by members of the task team or by specialists in the relevant area. This is especially likely for legal, policy, methodological, or governance guidance.